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Writing women's worlds

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Sabra's mother did not want her daughter to be a widow. She said no. Her husband was angry, she told me. "What am I supposed to tell them? I already agreed," he had said. He then marched off on foot to talk to his niece's mother, to enlist her support. But she, too, refused to let Selima, her only daughter, marry into that family. The women suggested that he inform his friends that the girls' male cousins had asserted their right to claim them. He would save face, and Sabra and Selima would not have to go. And that is what happened.

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Another request, from the family of Sabra's father's third wife, Azza, had been trickier to deal with. The accounts I heard conflicted, and, knowing Haj Sagr's deteriorating feelings toward his wife and her relatives, I believed none of them.

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According to one sister's version, Sabra's father had set tough conditions for Azza's family, but these had been met: a high brideprice of five thousand Egyptian pounds (then worth about \$2,500) and a separate house for Sabra to live in away from the man's parents. The house was built in Matruh, and they even, it is said, put in electricity. But then Sabra's cousin claimed her. He went, according to this version, and informed the prospective groom that unless he arranged to give his own cousin to the new claimant in exchange, the man could not have Sabra. The poor would-be groom protested. Had it been a sister he might have managed, but in his Egyptianized town family he had no say over his cousin.

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Sabra's version was different. The man, she insisted, had not asked specifically for her: rather, he would take any of her father's daughters. Moreover, it was Azza who had approached Sagr, and he had told her he had no objections. They settled on a day when the family would come to make arrangements. In the meantime, though, Sabra's uncle Hamid had run into Azza's relatives at the market. When he had asked who the groom was to be, one of the men, joking, had pointed to an old lame man who was with them. 📌

173 Her uncle was furious: no way would his family give one of their girls to that old cripple. The men had just been joking, but Sabra's uncle had made up his mind. The next thing they knew, he had sent his son to demand an exchange. In this version, too, the prospective groom had said, "We're not like you. We don't have any say over our cousins. Everyone is responsible only for himself." Sabra's cousin had said then that the man could not have her, so the groom and his family got angry and did not come on the appointed day.

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